FRIENDS from 1A

est and best friends, and Watters says Levi was just a normal 11-year-old boy with best friends of his own.

Sometimes meeting in groups sometimes talking one-on-one, Watters says the most important thing is for she and other counselors to let the children share their feelings.

"We do more listening than talking, and the children talk about how they feel and share memories about Levi. We want to know what life is like for them" without him.

Watters says "children go through the grieving process differently than do adults:" Because Levi's friends are so young, she says this "may be the first personal loss – where they truly miss someone – which many children have ever experienced."

Initially, the grief is "on the surface" she said, but now it surfaces in "more subtle ways."

When children lose someone close the them, Watters says it is common for them to channel their sadness in other areas: "They will act out, have less self control or be angrier," she says, "and they may not even be aware that they are really feeling sad."

So, parents and teachers can sometimes mistake the change in behavior and not realize "it's really grief."

To help, Watters says counselors try to "reassure children that their feelings are natural," and have assigned many of the children to volunteer mentors.

Watters says the mentors undergo thorough background screenings and are available to "spend time with the kids and do special things" to help them cope.

Although she describes the atmosphere as one of "edginess right now," she doesn't see evidence of the "fear and shock" so apparent in the early aftermath of Levi's slaying.

"They would like to know what happened – to know why, but mostly they just talk about missing Levi and what he was like."

Even though Watters says most of the children don't seem overly fearful, she says many seem "frustrated" that their parents are afraid to let them go outside and play as they did before.

"Their lifestyles have changed," she said. "Whereas kids used to run loose and do what they wanted, now they can't play in the woods as before, and they're more restricted."

Watters says the school has no immediate plans for a memorial service for Levi, although she expects some type of permanent memorial to his life will eventually be designated.

"Right now, we're trying to get some distance between the children and Levi's death and let things normalize." To hold a service at this point, she says, would be too upsetting. "Adults can handle that, but children can't."

PRECINCT from 1A

Hendrix said community reaction has been excellent.

The precinct receives dozens of walk-ins each day, and provides citizens with an alternative to going to the jail or having a deputy come to their house, said Hendrix.

During the precinct's opening ceremony, Hendrix said he would like to have a permanent precinct opened in the north end of the county by the end of 1998.

But he said the Frady murder has increased the need for more law enforcement presence immediately.

The temporary precinct will give law enforcement a place to coordinate their efforts on the murder investigation.

Patrols in the north end have already been increased, said Hendrix. A temporary precinct will enable the extra deputies to save time by not driving to headquarters in Cumming before and after each shift.

Commissioner Andy Anderson was asked to help look for a location, said the sheriff.

During the opening of Precinct 1, Anderson said he fully supported the idea of precincts and would help anyway he could to open a permanent one in the county's north end.

Hendrix said he still hopes to have another permanent precinct open by the end of next year.

SUPPORT from 1A

Child services has help this year through a state law which suspends drivers and professional licenses of "dead-beat" parents.

Since the law went into effect in October of 1996, 2,894 driver's licenses have been suspended or not reissued state wide.

In the Blue Ridge Circuit, which is comprised of Forsyth and Cherokee counties, 22 suspensions have been made. Two professional licenses, both builders, were also suspended.

Whitman said the effect of the threat of suspension has been extremely effective in Forsyth County.

"This has been a very good program so far, especially in this area with all the construction," said Whitman. "People depend on their driver's license for their jobs."

> ***"This has been a very good program ... people depend on their driver's license for their jobs."***

More than 60 people in the two counties have been in contact with children services since the law went into effect.

"Dead-beat" parents were contacted by G.C. Services, a collection agency, for the first eight months of the program.

Children services took over in June. More than $4 million was collected between June and October.

Whitman said that figure includes back taxes and other payments, but a little more than $1.3 million is child support.

He said he sees the figure getting larger as more and more collection tools are implemented by the state.

Legislation has already been passed to tap into Individual Retirement Accounts and bank accounts of delinquent parents. Whitman said they are waiting for final procedures to be established before implementing the program.

State and local agencies are also considering flagging "dead-beat" parents through tag registration, passports and hunting and fishing licenses.

GUILTY from 1A

After getting between $75 and $85 from the cash register, Teal put the clerk and a customer in the bathroom and escaped in a late-1970s Chevrolet Impala.

A paper bag was found on a county road several days later containing a wig and makeup.

Warrants were issued July 3 after investigators found additional evidence linking him to the crime. At the time, investigator Thurman Atkinson said Teal was out of the county, probably in South Carolina.

He originally entered a plea of not guilty on Oct. 15, but changed his plea to guilty on a lesser charge Monday.

Teal pleaded guilty to robbery by intimidation and one count of kidnapping.

The Probation Department is conducting a pre-sentence investigation. Teal will return to court at a later date for sentencing.

A June 23 robbery of the same store remains unsolved.

A black male suspect in his late 20s reportedly held an employee and customer at gunpoint, forced them into a stock room and stole their jewelry.

The suspect reportedly beat the customer, then fired a shot into the ceiling when she ran.

Maj. Ernie Born said investigators have several leads and one good suspect in that case.

Sheriff's office incident report summary

By Michael Kurtz
Staff Writer

A Leland Drive company was reportedly robbed between Nov. 21-23. Missing items are valued at more than $61,000.

According to the Sheriff's Office report, the front gate of the property was propped open with a sledge hammer.

A Coke machine, vending machine and refrigerator in one of the company's trailers had been pushed to the middle of the trailer. Everything else in the trailer was scattered.

The front windows of another building were all broken out.

Two Ford pickup trucks, which had been parked in front of the buildings, were stolen.

One is a blue, 1991 Ford F-150 with Georgia tag 459BRS. The other is a white, 1995 Ford F-350. The tag number was not available.

A sump pump, a pair of Red Wing hunting boots, a briefcase, two Motorola radios and other construction equipment and gear were also stolen.

Other incidents reported to the Sheriff's Office include:

• A 1994 Chevrolet pick-up truck was stolen from Regal Chemical, a Branch Drive company, between Nov. 21-24. The truck is burgundy and silver with Georgia tag 461BSH.

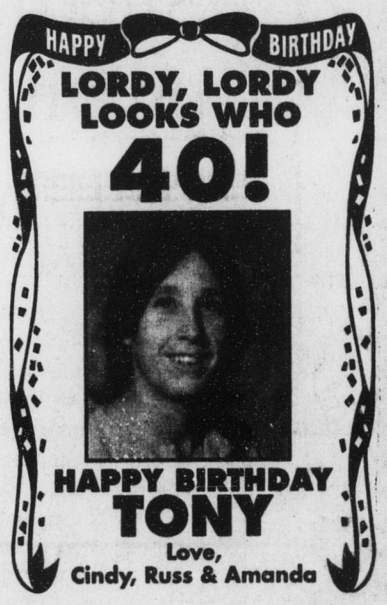
• Two black horse outline signs were stolen from the entrance of Etowah Trails subdivision between Nov. 22-23. The signs were mounted to the subdivision's brick entrance.

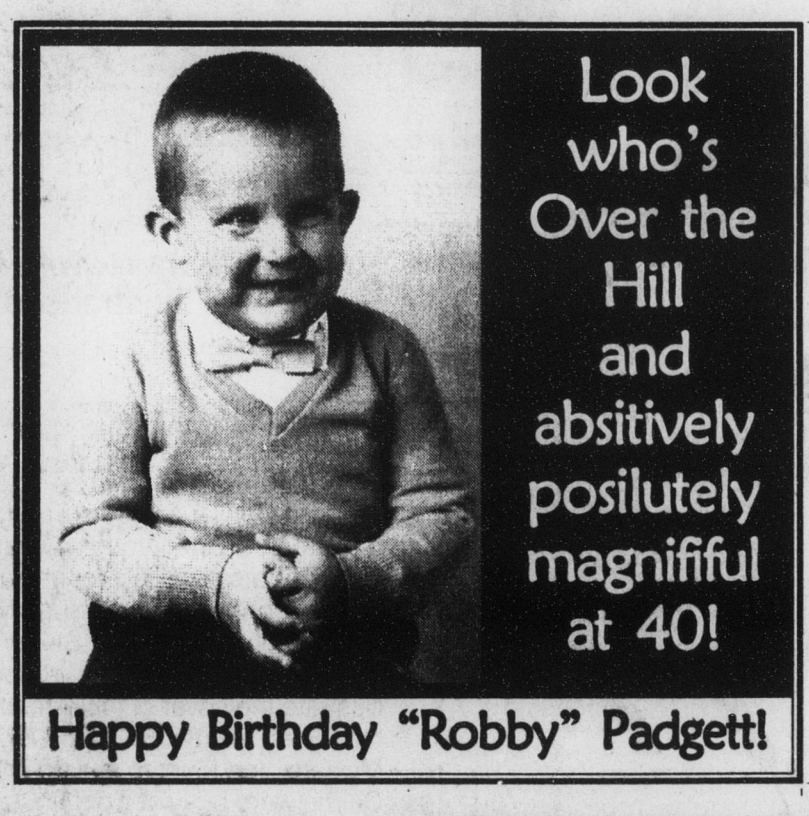
• Someone splashed motor oil on the outside wall of a Sawnee Lane residence on Nov. 22. In addition, A mattress and couch were set on the front porch, the inside carpet was stained and a window to the upstairs bedroom was broken.

• Several sets of golf clubs and a golf bag were stolen from the Old Atlanta Golf Club clubhouse on Nov. 25. According to the report, someone broke the clubhouse's stained-glass window to gain entrance. The items are valued at $10,000.

• A Motorola cellular telephone was stolen out of a car parked at Hammonds Store on Nov. 21. The car was left unlocked, states the report.

• The right front and two rear tires were stolen from a 1988 Ford Mustang parked at a Pine Ridge Circle address between Nov. 22-23. The lug nuts were replaced on the car and nothing else was missing, states the report.







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Advertising Deadlines

For Sunday's paper retail and classified display ads are due by noon Thursday.
For Wednesday's paper retail and classified display ads are due by 5 p.m. Friday.
For Friday's paper retail and classified display ads are due by noon Tuesday.

Classified Line Advertising Deadlines
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